

Swallow

Often seen gliding over fields as they hunt for flying insects, barn swallows are swallows that breed among buildings. After raising their chicks, most that live in the Northern Hemisphere fly off to spend winter in warmer climates in the south. These barn swallows from northern Europe, for example, migrate to southern Africa.

Migration is tough: many birds die through exhaustion, starvation, or in violent storms.

Winter in Africa

When they reach southern Africa, the swallows' journey is over—for now. They spend the winter near wetland habitats, where the air is abuzz with flying insects to feast on.

Flying south

Barn swallows may raise two broods a year. In fall, after all their chicks have learned to fly, and after growing a new set of feathers, the swallows gather in large groups and fly south.

Arctic tern This record-holding bird makes the longest migration of all, from the Arctic to the Antarctic and back again—a total distance of 44,000 miles (70,000 km). It rests on the way, so it doesn't match the godwit for nonstop flight.

Starlings Migrating starlings often come together to form a huge cloud of birds that twists and turns in the air. Birds of prey find it harder to pick out individuals in the swirling mass.